Dravid and Sanjay Bangar, our makeshift opener for the game, put together an excellent partnership of 170 that turned things our way. Batting wasn't easy on a fresh wicket and they both played exceptionally well, leaving a lot of balls outside the off stump.

I went in to bat in the last session of day one and decided to wear an inner-thigh guard. I had never used one before, even in practice, but Andrew Flintoff was getting the ball to jag back in to the batsmen and I thought the inner-thigh guard might be a sensible protection against injury. However, I soon realized that my stance had completely changed. Normally the forearm of my bottom hand rests on my thigh while I take stance, but at Headingley it felt completely different because of the new guard. I immediately decided to get rid of it and the experiment was never tried again.

In this innings I was circumspect to start with and decided to play out the day, waiting for my opportunity the next morning. Flintoff bowled a hostile spell and I really had to knuckle down. He was getting the ball to swing and bounce and there was not much I could do but defend. The following morning Matthew Hoggard, who had the ability to swing the ball both ways, also bowled impressively, getting the ball to move away from the bat at good pace. Quality outswing is difficult to negotiate and I had to be watchful while playing big drives on the rise. Shot selection in this innings was the key.

Andrew Flintoff produced another really probing spell. He was bowling into Sourav's body and it was decided that I would face up to him while Sourav, a left-hander, took as much strike as possible against Ashley Giles, who was once again bowling a defensive line to me outside my leg stump. When we went back for tea to the dressing room, Sourav said, '*Woh beech wale Flintoff ka spell humne kya jhela yaar.*' (We did really well to see off Flintoff's spell.) I couldn't resist pulling his leg and jokingly said to him, '*Humne jhela? Saala maine jhela hain!*' (Did *we*? I was the one who negotiated Flintoff!) The whole dressing room burst out laughing.

In the third session of the day we shifted gears and launched into the English bowlers, who were gradually starting to tire. It was one of those rare matches in which we refused to take the light even when the umpires offered it to us. We were dominating proceedings and there was no reason to go off.